



Checked, Not Counted

Self-Certified Completeness Cards Against a Term-End Board-Game Piece Audit

Petra Umbile · Anouk Mensah — School of Emergent Priorities

Background

The Union Building common room's board-game shelf pairs each box with a laminated card: the last borrower ticks a piece-count checklist and initials it complete. Whether that self-certification tracks what an independent count would actually find has never been checked.

Aims

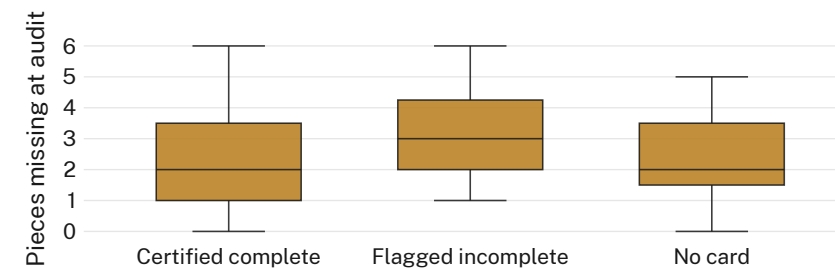
- Quantify borrower trust in a game's laminated completeness card before taking it
- Independently audit all 34 shelf games against each box's published piece list
- Test whether card-certified "complete" predicts an audited-complete result

Study design

- 112 exit-survey borrowers rated their trust in a game's card (1–5) at the point of taking it, one 13-week term
- all 34 shelf games counted twice, blind to certification history, at term end
- certification category (complete · flagged incomplete · no card) fixed before audit; none excluded post hoc

Findings

Trust tracks the card closely ($r = 0.58$); the audit does not ($r = 0.11$). Certified-complete games are still missing a median of 2 pieces.



Median pieces missing at the week-13 audit: 2 for card-certified-complete games, 3 for card-flagged-incomplete, 2 for games with no card at all ($n = 34$ games) — the certified group is not meaningfully cleaner than games with no card at all.

Discussion & conclusions

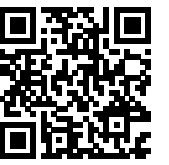
Self-certification predicts confidence, not completeness. A tick appears to record relief at finishing the game, not a count of its pieces. The card's category explains more of a borrower's trust than of the shelf's actual state. Next: trial a photographed lay-out check at return, logged automatically rather than self-reported.

Selected references

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Piece audits conducted after hours, blind to certification history; no borrower named. We thank common-room volunteers for return-desk access.

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Certified-complete games are still missing a median of 2 pieces at term-end audit ($n = 34$).